What We Used

Cool Edit Pro	Recording and cleaning up
MP3 Gain	Volume levelling
ID3 TagIT	Renaming and tagging
Nero	Write to CD
Advanced MP3	
Catalog Pro	Make a database of your files

hit [Delete]. In Audacity, you need to select it, and then go to ***Edit > Delete***, where you will see that the shortcut key is actually ***[Ctrl] + [K]***. Most operations, such as loading files, saving, editing etc. happen just as speedily as they do in other programs. But the program was unstable at times, and crashed while opening more than one large file. Audacity has a lot of effects and filters that are labelled simply, enabling novices to understand them too.

The Noise Removal tool included precise instructions, telling you to select a sample and make a profile, then return to remove the noise. This was really nice, compared to the other software, which left us bewildered with the array of complicated settings that were not of much assistance.

Let's record then...

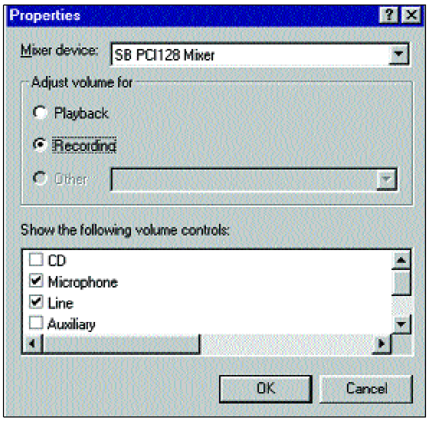
Time to get down to actually recording your files. There are several tools that we used; You may use one of the alternatives we've tested here, or any other software that you're comfortable with.

The first thing you need to do is get the music on to the PC. Recording is actually the most crucial step in this entire process. If something is not right here, the problem becomes all the more difficult to deal with as we proceed further. It is also the stage where the smallest changes can have the biggest impact on the eventual audio quality. So, it's worth spending a little extra time to get it done properly.

For starters, ensure that your cassette deck is in peak condition—get it serviced, if necessary. Choose your connecting cables with care—OFC cables perform much better than standard wires. Try, and avoid unnecessary adapters and connectors—the more links there are, the more the chances of loss in quality. Use a single direct cable, and plug it from the Line Out of your deck to the Line In of your sound card. The connectors on your deck or sound card may have developed carbon deposits, manifesting into a loud crackling sound when you twist the plug in the socket. You can remove this by using a contact cleaner.

Before you begin, it's a good idea to ensure you have enough disk space for your recording. An hour of wave-file audio will take approximately 600 MB on your hard disk. Though some applications support it, recording directly to MP3 is not advisable, as the audio is compressed. When further processing is done on these files, the quality degrades rapidly. You should also defragment your hard disk for optimal performance.

Now, open the Windows Volume Control menu by double-clicking on the speaker icon in the Taskbar. Alternatively, you can go to ***Start > Programs > Accessories > Entertainment > Volume Control***. From the menu, select ***Options > Properties***. Ensure that the correct sound card is listed as the Mixer Device, and then select the Recording radio button. Also, ensure that the checkbox for your input source is selected below (Line In or Microphone), and then click OK. The window now changes to the Recording Control Window. Select the checkbox for the input source you are using, and set the volume temporarily to the Maximum.



Select your source and set your recording level here

Launch Cool Edit Pro (CEP). If you have a previous mix, or wave file open, close it, and make a new file. Play your tape to check if you can hear it through your PC speakers. This indicates that the audio is coming through correctly. Next, double-click the level meters at the bottom of the screen to enable the level preview before recording. If the level reaches the end, and the red lights come on, then the sound is too loud, and is clipped. Sound that is clipped, is lost. Avoid this by reducing the volume till it is just short of reaching the red lights. If no sound comes through, double-check the Recording Options, and make sure that the selected source is the correct one.

Now, rewind your tape to the beginning. Press the recording button in CEP, and select 44 KHz, 16-bit Stereo quality. Click OK to start recording, and then begin playing the tape. It is important to start the recording early, and not just before the song starts. That will make the noise reduction process easier and more effective. You can record the entire tape as one wave file, and split them later. Stop the recording when the tape runs out and save it as a wave file. Repeat the procedure for Side B.

After the recording is done, and the files are saved, clean up the sound and split it into tracks. In the Edit mode, load one of the wave files. First, remove the ➜

Nothing like CD

No matter how much effort you put into it, your recordings will not match the sound quality of an original CD that is mastered in a studio. If you wish to add your own CDs to your music collection, or just keep them in MP3 format, you should use a CD-Ripper to rip them onto your disk directly. This way, you ensure the highest possible quality, and it's likely to be done several times faster than recording through your sound card.

Another benefit of ripping from a CD is that the file name and ID3 tags are filled in automatically by most ripping tools. They get this information from online databases of pre-recorded CDs, such as CDDB or FreeDB. You can also add your custom compilations to these databases for free, so when you carry your CD to your friend's place, that PC will automatically download the track names.